

MICHAEL A. MELENDEZ

Game Designer • Systems Designer • Technical Designer

Bakersfield, CA • Open to Remote

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SUMMARY

Game Designer focused on systems, combat, and narrative structure. Blends a BS in Game & Simulation Programming with technical prototyping in Unity/C# and 10+ years of engineering experience. Designs modular systems, TCG mechanics, and branching narrative supported by clear GDD/TDD documentation. CORE SKILLS

Systems Design • Combat Design • TCG Mechanics • Progression • Balancing • Encounter Design • Narrative Systems • Unity • C# • C++ • Prototyping • Scripting • Git • Worldbuilding • Branching Narrative • GDD/TDD Writing

GAME DESIGN PROJECTS

Champions of Rymora — Original Trading Card Game

Systems Design • Game Design • Balancing

- Designed a complete TCG rules engine including resource systems, timing windows, zone interactions, and faction identities.
- Authored full GDD/TDD documentation covering card types, abilities, turn structure, and edge-case rules.
- Built a modular card database and balancing framework for scalable iteration.

Unity Turn-Based Battle System — Modular Combat Framework

Technical Design • Systems Design • Unity/C#

- Built a fully functional 2D turn-based combat system with modular architecture for reuse across RPG projects.
- Implemented turn logic, ability systems, enemy AI, status effects, and party mechanics.
- Designed data-driven configuration for rapid iteration and customization.

Fangs of the Frost Wyrms — D&D 5e One-Shot

Narrative Design • Encounter Design

- Designed a 3–5 hour adventure featuring wilderness survival, environmental hazards, and multi-phase combat.
- Authored full adventure module, companion guide, and playtest notes.

Fangs of the Frost Wyrms — Solo CYOA Adaptation

Narrative Systems • Branching Narrative

- Converted the one-shot into a fully branching solo adventure with state tracking and multiple endings.
- Designed four dynamic archetypes with unique narrative and mechanical outcomes.

Fal'shari — Warcraft Lore Bible

Worldbuilding • Narrative Design

- Created an extensive lore bible integrating an original elven research collective into Warcraft's world.
- Developed characters, factions, locations, and thematic pillars aligned with existing canon.

Crestfall — Horror Novel (In Progress)

Narrative Design

- Writing a character-driven supernatural horror novel with psychological tension and ensemble storytelling.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Software Engineer (2012–Present)

- Built production-ready systems in C++, C#, JavaScript, and Python with a focus on clarity and modularity.
- Collaborated with cross-disciplinary teams to implement features aligned with user experience goals.
- Created tools and internal systems that improved workflow efficiency and iteration speed.

- Applied engineering expertise to support gameplay prototyping, data structures, and system scalability.

EDUCATION

BS in Game & Simulation Programming — DeVry University

Capstone: Custom C++ game engine, GDD/TDD authorship, systems design specialization

TOOLS & TECHNOLOGIES

Unity • C# • C++ • Git • VS Code • React • Python • JSON • ScriptableObjects • Jira • Notion